

September Business Starter Bank

30 ready-to-project do-now activities for the first weeks back - GCSE and A-Level Business

What's inside

A - Retrieval quick-fives - 5 sets of 5 rapid recall questions (basics, marketing, finance, people, operations)

B - Real-company hooks - 5 discussion starters built on Gymshark, Aldi, M&S, Greggs and Pret, with real figures

C - Quick calcs - 5 calculation starters with full worked answers

D - Key-term ladders - define, example, apply: 5 core terms

E - Debate prompts - 5 agree/disagree starters

F - Spot the mistake - 5 wrong statements for students to correct, with answers

How to use: project one starter as students walk in, or print a section as a settling task. Every activity runs in 5-10 minutes with no prep. Answers and teacher notes on page 7.

Spec links: AQA GCSE 8132 - Edexcel GCSE 1BS0 - Cambridge IGCSE 0450 - AQA A-Level 7132 - Edexcel A-Level 9BS0

Section A - Retrieval quick-fives

Project one set. Students answer all five in their books in 5 minutes, then peer-mark. Marking guidance on page 7.

Set 1 - Business basics

1. What is an entrepreneur?
2. Name two rewards and two risks of starting a business.
3. What does 'opportunity cost' mean?
4. What is the difference between a good and a service?
5. Give one reason a business might set a non-financial objective.

Set 2 - Marketing

1. Name the four elements of the marketing mix.
2. What is market segmentation?
3. Give two ways a business can segment its market.
4. What is the difference between primary and secondary market research?
5. Why might a business choose penetration pricing for a new product?

Set 3 - Finance

1. State the formula for total revenue.
2. What is the difference between fixed and variable costs?
3. State the formula for gross profit.
4. What does 'break-even output' mean?
5. Give two reasons a profitable business can still run out of cash.

Set 4 - People

1. What is a flat organisational structure?
2. Give two financial and two non-financial methods of motivation.
3. What does 'span of control' mean?
4. What is the difference between internal and external recruitment?
5. Why might high labour turnover worry a manager?

Set 5 - Operations

1. Name three methods of production.
2. When would job production suit a business best?
3. What is 'just in time' stock management?
4. What is the difference between quality control and quality assurance?
5. Give two ways good customer service benefits a business.

Section B - Real-company hooks

Read the snapshot aloud or project it. Students discuss the question in pairs for 5 minutes, then feed back. All figures from company statements and reporting, 2024-2026.

Hook 6 - Gymshark

Gymshark was founded in Birmingham in 2012 by 19-year-old Ben Francis. By FY25 revenue reached around £646m, selling to roughly 230 countries - but profit before tax was only around £7m.

Discuss: Big revenue, small profit. What could explain the gap - and should the owners worry?

Hook 7 - Aldi

Aldi stocks around 1,800 product lines. A traditional big supermarket carries closer to 30,000. Aldi's UK sales hit £18.1bn in 2024, and it holds around 10.2% of the UK grocery market (Kantar, Jan 2026).

Discuss: How does stocking far fewer products help Aldi charge lower prices? Think about buying power, stores and staff.

Hook 8 - M&S

In 2025 a cyber attack forced M&S to suspend online orders for 46 days. The estimated hit to operating profit: around £300m.

Discuss: List every stakeholder group harmed by the attack. Which one was hurt most - and can a business ever fully prepare for this?

Hook 9 - Greggs

Greggs' revenue passed £2bn in FY24 (£2.01bn) and it now trades from over 2,600 UK shops - with plans for more.

Discuss: Greggs could raise prices instead of opening shops. Why might opening more shops be the better route to higher revenue?

Hook 10 - Pret A Manger

Pret sells a coffee subscription that currently costs around £30 per month for multiple barista drinks a day.

Discuss: Why would a business sell coffee on subscription rather than per cup? What is the biggest risk of this pricing model?

Section C - Quick calcs

One calculation on the board as students settle. Full worked answers on page 7. Calculators fine; the point is method.

Calc 11 - Gross profit margin

A bakery's sales revenue last month was £200,000. Cost of sales was £120,000.

Task: Calculate the gross profit margin. Give your answer as a percentage.

Calc 12 - Contribution and break-even

A student enterprise sells reusable cups at £3.20 each. Variable cost per cup is £1.10. Fixed costs are £1,050 per month.

Task: Calculate (a) the contribution per cup and (b) the break-even output per month.

Calc 13 - Percentage change

Aldi's UK operating profit fell from £552.9m in 2023 to £435.5m in 2024.

Task: Calculate the percentage change in operating profit. Give your answer to 1 decimal place.

Calc 14 - Profit margin (PBT)

Gymshark's FY25 revenue was around £646m. Profit before tax was around £7m.

Task: Calculate the profit margin (PBT divided by revenue). Give your answer to 1 decimal place. What does it tell you?

Calc 15 - Revenue and profit

A market stall sells 1,200 phone cases in a month at £5 each. Total costs for the month are £4,800.

Task: Calculate (a) total revenue and (b) profit for the month.

Section D - Key-term ladders

Three steps per term: define it, give a real example, apply it. Students climb as far as they can in 6 minutes.

Term (Step 1: define - Step 2: real example)	Step 3 - Apply it
16 - Opportunity cost	A school leaver takes a job instead of going to university. What is given up?
17 - Market segmentation	How might a trainer brand segment its customers? Name two segments and how the marketing would differ.
18 - Cash flow	A shop's customers pay in 60 days but suppliers want paying in 30. What is the danger?
19 - Added value	A cafe buys coffee beans for pence and sells a flat white for pounds. Where exactly is the value added?
20 - Economies of scale	Why can a supermarket chain sell a tin of beans for less than a corner shop can?

Section E - Debate prompts

Project one statement. Corners of the room = strongly agree / agree / disagree / strongly disagree. Students must justify with a business concept, not an opinion.

21 - "Cutting prices is the best way for a supermarket to win customers."
22 - "Social media has made traditional advertising pointless."
23 - "A business whose customer data is stolen should compensate every affected customer."
24 - "Paying workers more always motivates them to work harder."
25 - "A business should never borrow money if it can avoid it."

Pairings that work: prompt 21 with Hook 7 (Aldi) - prompt 22 with Hook 6 (Gymshark) - prompt 23 with Hook 8 (M&S) - prompt 24 with any motivation lesson - prompt 25 before teaching sources of finance.

Section F - Spot the mistake

Each statement contains one error. Students find it, correct it, and explain why the original is wrong. Corrections on page 7.

Mistake 26

"A sole trader benefits from limited liability, so their personal savings are safe if the business fails."

Find it - correct it - explain why the original is wrong.

Mistake 27

"Break-even output is calculated by multiplying fixed costs by the contribution per unit."

Find it - correct it - explain why the original is wrong.

Mistake 28

"A private limited company (Ltd) raises money by selling its shares to the public on the stock market."

Find it - correct it - explain why the original is wrong.

Mistake 29

"If a business increases its revenue, its profit must increase too."

Find it - correct it - explain why the original is wrong.

Mistake 30

"Job production is the best method for making thousands of identical products at low unit cost."

Find it - correct it - explain why the original is wrong.

Stretch: students write their own 'spot the mistake' statement on last year's hardest topic and swap with a partner.

Answers and teacher notes

Section C - Quick calcs (worked)

Q	Worked answer
11	Gross profit = £200,000 - £120,000 = £80,000. GPM = $80,000 / 200,000 \times 100 = 40\%$.
12	(a) Contribution = £3.20 - £1.10 = £2.10 per cup. (b) Break-even = £1,050 / £2.10 = 500 cups per month.
13	Change = 435.5 - 552.9 = -117.4. Percentage = $-117.4 / 552.9 \times 100 = -21.2\%$.
14	$7 / 646 \times 100 = 1.1\%$. For every pound of sales, only about a penny is profit before tax - margins in fast-growing retail brands can be very thin.
15	(a) Revenue = $1,200 \times £5 = \text{£}6,000$. (b) Profit = £6,000 - £4,800 = £1,200 .

Section F - Corrections

Q	Correction
26	Sole traders have unlimited liability - personal assets are at risk. Limited liability belongs to shareholders in Ltd and PLC companies.
27	Break-even = fixed costs divided by contribution per unit, not multiplied.
28	Only a public limited company (PLC) can sell shares to the public on a stock market. An Ltd sells shares privately.
29	Not necessarily - if costs rise faster than revenue, profit falls. ASOS made £2.9bn of revenue in FY24 and still recorded a £331m operating loss.
30	That describes flow production. Job production suits one-off, custom items - high unit cost, high flexibility.

Sections A, D, E - guidance

Quick-fives: all answers are standard textbook definitions - peer-marking against the class textbook works well and saves you the marking. **Ladders:** accept any accurate real example; push students from Step 2 to Step 3 verbally.

Debates: the win condition is using a concept correctly (price elasticity, brand loyalty, motivation theory, gearing) - not the side students pick.

Want your students to run a business for real?

These starters warm a class up. The Business School simulation lets them actually do it: students form companies in teams, set prices, hire staff, take out loans, file VAT and negotiate deals - live against the other teams in the room. One 60-minute session, up to 5 teams and 30 students. You get a live teacher dashboard, automatic grading and student certificates. Browser-based, no installation - students join with a PIN.

The autumn 2026 cohort is full - but you can join the waitlist for the next round at thebusiness.school. More free resources live at thebusiness.school/resources.

Sources

Company figures as used in this pack: Gymshark company filings and reporting (FY25 revenue ~£646m, PBT ~£7m; founded 2012, Birmingham); Aldi press releases and reporting (2024 UK sales £18.1bn, operating profit £435.5m from £552.9m; ~1,800 lines); Kantar grocery share data (Jan 2026); M&S trading statements and reporting on the 2025 cyber incident (46-day online suspension, ~£300m estimated profit impact); Greggs plc annual report FY24 (revenue £2.01bn, 2,600+ shops); Pret A Manger published subscription pricing (~£30/month); ASOS plc annual report FY24 (revenue £2.9bn, £331m operating loss). All figures rounded and correct to the best of our knowledge at time of writing (July 2026). This pack is not affiliated with or endorsed by any company named.

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